was actually a very frightful place.' Chandagirika enjoyed full sway in these quarters, revelling in the infliction of all kinds of torture on prisoners, and, when the king allowed, ensuring they never emerged alive.[4]

Sadistic cruelty is virtually a literary trope in Buddhist hagiography, the objective being to show radical and fundamental transformation in temperament and personality consequent upon conversion. Because Ashoka would soon be shown as the ideal Buddhist ruler in the *Ashokavadana*, episodes of extreme cruelty were almost required insertions. The moral change in the king would stand out so much better against an exceptionally brutish background in which he was shown cold-bloodedly killing off even his immediate circle of ministers and concubines. This image of Ashoka is not confined to the Northern tradition; it figures in the Sri Lankan tradition as well. The *Mahavamsa* briefly alludes to it when noting that Chandashoka was so called in ancient times because of his evil deeds; later, through his pious acts, he came to be known as Dhammashoka.[5]

It is possible, of course, that these representations of a merciless monarch were a redeployment of elements that formed part of the accepted remembrance of Ashoka's earlier years of violence-filled usurpation. Cruelty could not have been far during the early period of Ashoka's rule because it is almost certain that he got rid of his older half-brother, and possibly several others who had supported the rightful heir. And this may not have been just a palace revolution: the resistance to his kingly ambitions was likely to have extended beyond the royal family. Who resisted him and how remain unknown. If the records of the Sri Lankan Buddhist tradition are relied upon, it took some four years after his bid for the throne for him to be finally consecrated. This was around 269 BCE, some four years after the death of Bindusara. The interregnum can only really be explained as the context of sustained opposition. And if he consolidated his position ruthlessly, there was bound to have been collateral damage.